Pathao: a product teardown

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I have used Pathao for more than eight years, so this teardown mixes that experience with public reporting. Sources are numbered in brackets and listed at the end. The suggestions are my own ideas, not company plans.

What it is

Pathao started in 2015 and calls itself Bangladesh's first super app. For its tenth anniversary it cited 10 million users, 300,000 riders and delivery agents, and 200,000 merchants, spread across rides, food, parcels and payments [1]. It won a Superbrands award in the super app category in 2025 [2]. A travel guide lists it in Dhaka, Chattogram, Khulna, Sylhet and Nepal, and notes Uber also runs in Dhaka [8].

Who uses it and why

The first problem was simple: getting across Dhaka takes forever and you can't predict how long. Motorbike rides gave people their time back, and that daily habit is what everything else is built on. Food delivery came later, in 2018 [7], then parcels, then payments.

It is a marketplace, so there are two sides to keep happy. Commuters, diners and senders are one side. Riders, delivery agents and merchants are the other.

How it earns

Food delivery in Bangladesh runs mostly on commission from restaurants [9]. I would assume rides and parcels work in a similar way, but I could not confirm Pathao's exact model from public sources. Payments are the newest piece. Pathao's payments arm got a payment service provider licence from Bangladesh Bank in 2023 [5]. Pathao Pay soft-launched to selected users in March 2024 with early cashback [4], and launched fully in July 2025 [3].

What I have noticed as a long-time user

The biggest problem I have run into is what happens when a ride is discounted. On some of my discounted rides, the rider has asked me for extra money. As I understand it, Pathao pays the discount amount into the rider's account, but the rider still feels the fare is too low. When I have refused, I have worried about a bad review or a lower rating, because a passenger rating can follow you around the app.

I don't think this is a "bad riders" problem. It looks more like a marketplace incentive problem: a discounted trip can look like a low fare to the person doing the work, even if they are paid in full behind the scenes. Riders are the supply side, so if they feel underpaid, the whole service suffers.

On the payment side, Pathao Pay covers rides, food and parcels, plus bill splitting and sending money. Users add money by card or Nagad, and there is a Mastercard-powered Pathao Pay

Card backed by Mutual Trust Bank. The launch offered up to Tk3,000 in cashback across services [3]. In 2024 Pathao also added accident cover for riders and passengers during rides [6].

Against the competition

In food, a March 2026 report cited by a travel guide puts Pathao Food third, behind foodpanda and Foodi [8]. In rides, Uber is the rival in Dhaka [8]. In payments, Pathao Pay is up against wallets people already use every day, like bKash and Nagad.

What works

The ride habit is strong and the brand is local [1][2]. Having several services under one login helps, and so does the payment licence [5]. The accident cover was a real selling point when it launched [6].

What doesn't

Rider trust and pay clarity are the weak spots, as I described above. If a discount makes riders feel underpaid, passengers end up in awkward conversations about extra cash, and ratings can turn into a pressure tool.

Food is also an easy place to lose people. Customers compare apps and go with the cheaper one, so loyalty has to come from somewhere else [8]. And payments have a friction problem: launch coverage listed cards and Nagad as ways to add money and did not mention bKash [3]. Options may have changed since then, but a wallet is a hard sell if people can't top it up from the wallet they already use. Big cashback offers also tend to attract people who leave once the rewards stop [3].

What I would change

1. Make discounted rides fair for riders and safe for passengers. Four small changes would cover it. Show the rider their full earnings before they accept, for example "You'll earn Tk X, including Tk Y covered by Pathao", so a discounted ride never looks like a low fare. Add an "extra payment requested" button so a passenger can flag it with one tap. Pause the rating a rider gives a passenger while that flag is under review, so a refusal can't turn into a low rating. And look at patterns across several flagged rides, not single incidents, so one disagreement doesn't cost anyone their income. To test it, roll it out to a small group of riders and passengers and compare flagged rides and cancellations with a control group. The risk is extra work for support, and riders may feel the system favours passengers, so rider earnings per hour need watching.

2. Make topping up easier, and make Pathao Pay the default at checkout. A wallet only creates loyalty if people actually put money in it and use it. I would add more local ways to top up and preselect Pathao Pay when someone pays. To test it, compare how many people pay with Pathao Pay when it is preselected against a control group. The risk is cost: every new top-up channel adds integration work and fraud exposure.

How I would measure it

For discounted rides, I would track the share of those rides flagged for extra-payment requests, rider acceptance and cancellation rates on them, and passenger complaints about ratings. I would watch rider earnings per hour to make sure the fix isn't hurting riders. For payments, the main number is how much of the payment volume goes through Pathao Pay, along with top-up completion.

Sources

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